

Lesson 13

Managing Workplace Conflicts



Warm-up

QUICK POLL OR SURVEY

Respond to polls or type your answers in the chat box:

1. Have you ever experienced conflict at work? (Yes/No)
2. What do you think are the common causes of conflict?





Role-Play

Scenario: *Two coworkers discuss a conflict regarding differing approaches to a project. The team member (Liam) believes that implementing a new strategy will enhance the project's outcome, while the team member (Sofia) is concerned about the risks associated with it.*

Liam: Hi Sofia, I think we should try the new marketing strategy I mentioned. It could really boost our results.

Sofia: I appreciate your enthusiasm, Liam, but I'm worried that making changes at this stage might **escalate** the risks. Our current approach has been working.

Liam: That's true, but if we don't innovate, we might fall behind our competitors. We need to be proactive to **resolve** any issues we have with engagement.

Sofia: I understand your perspective, but we need to evaluate the potential downsides first. What if it doesn't go as planned?

Liam: Maybe we can find a **middle ground**? We could test the new strategy on a smaller scale first to see if it actually works.

Sofia: That sounds reasonable! If it proves effective, we can consider a broader implementation later.

Liam: Great! I appreciate your willingness to **mediate** this discussion. Let's make sure we communicate openly about any concerns so we can work together more effectively.

Sofia: Definitely! I'll gather some data on our current strategy this week, and we can review it alongside the new plan.

Role-play Analysis

1. What is the main source of conflict between Liam and Sofia?
2. How does Sofia express her concerns about the new strategy?
3. What suggestion does Liam make to resolve the conflict?



Common Causes of Conflict in the Workplace

CAUSE	EXPLANATION
Poor Communication	Misunderstandings due to unclear messages or lack of information.
Different Values or Beliefs	Conflicts arising when individuals have differing personal values or cultural beliefs.
Role Ambiguity	Uncertainty regarding job responsibilities can lead to disputes over tasks and expectations.
Personality Clashes	Conflicts stemming from differing personality types or conflict styles.
Resource Competition	Struggles for limited resources, such as time, budget, or personnel, can lead to tensions between colleagues.
Change in Workplace Dynamics	Introduction of new policies, team members, or management styles can create uncertainty and conflict.
Stress and Workload	High-stress environments or excessive workloads can result in frustration, leading to conflicts between team members.
Lack of Support	Feeling unsupported by management or colleagues can lead to frustration and conflicts.



Practice

Activity: Gap Fill Dialogue

Complete the dialogue with the correct words.

	compromise	mediate	resolve
disagree	escalate	understand	middle ground

Brandon: I think we should increase the budget for marketing. We need to reach a wider audience.

Karla: I think we should focus on optimizing our current strategies before spending more.

Brandon: But if we don't increase our budget, we might lose market share. This could _____ into a bigger problem.

Karla: I _____ your point, but we need to be cautious with our expenses. How can we find a _____?

Brandon: We could allocate a smaller amount for marketing and monitor the results closely.

Karla: That sounds like a good _____. Let's discuss it with the team and see if we can _____ this issue.

Mediator: I'd like to _____ this discussion and help you both find a solution. What are your main concerns?



Stressed Syllables

Practice pronouncing these words with the correct stress:

1. **CON**flict /'kɒn.flɪkt/
2. **COM**promise /'kɒm.prə.maɪz/
3. **ME**diate /'mɪː.di.ət/
4. **ReSOLVE** /rɪ'zɒlv/
5. **ES**calate /'es.kə.leɪt/
6. **MID**dle ground /'mɪd.l graʊnd/



Production

CONFLICT ANALYSIS

1. **Work in Pairs or Small Groups**
2. **Read the Scenarios:** Each pair/group will be provided with conflict scenarios, each with a brief conversation.
3. **Analyze the Scenarios:**
 - What caused the conflict?
 - How might the conflict escalate if not addressed?
 - What are the possible impacts on the team or organization?
4. **Summarize** your group's findings on one scenario.
5. **Present:** When it's your group's turn, present your findings clearly and concisely.

SCENARIOS

Scenario 1: Two coworkers, Alex and Jamie, have ideas on how to approach a project.

Conversation:

- **Alex:** I think we should focus on using the new software for this project.
- **Jamie:** But we don't have enough time to learn it. I believe we should stick to the old way.
- **Alex:** If we don't try the new software, we'll miss out on potential improvements.

Scenario 2: A manager, Sarah, and her employee, Mark, are talking about a task deadline.

Conversation:

- **Sarah:** Mark, I need the report by Friday.
- **Mark:** I thought it was due next Monday. I already scheduled my work for this week.
- **Sarah:** No, I really need it by Friday for the meeting.

Scenario 3: Team members, Maria and Tom, are working on a joint project.

Conversation:

- **Maria:** I put in a lot of overtime to make this project successful, and I hope I'll be acknowledged.
- **Tom:** Well, I also worked hard on my part. It's not fair if you get all the credit.
- **Maria:** I just want our bosses to see how much effort I put in.

Discussion

1. How important is communication in preventing conflicts? Can you give examples?
2. How do cultural differences influence conflict resolution styles?
3. What signs indicate a conflict is escalating, and how can it be addressed?
4. How can managers effectively mediate conflicts? What qualities should a good mediator have?
5. What valuable lesson did you learn about managing conflicts, and how will you apply it?